



◀ LOCKED UP

Water can take centuries to return to the sea, and some may take even longer. Three-quarters of all the freshwater on Earth is frozen as ice in the polar regions and in mountain glaciers. Other water has been lying in natural underground reservoirs for thousands of years.



Snow falls on high ground

Snow melts to form meltwater streams

Clouds spill rain on ground below

▼ FLOWING STREAMS

Rainfall drains off the land in streams that join up to form rivers. The flowing water cuts valleys and waterfalls into the landscape, and carries sand and silt to lower ground. Here, the river flows more slowly and drops much of its sediment. Eventually, the water flows back out to sea.



Water seeps into the ground and flows to the sea

◀ GROUNDWATER

A lot of water seeps into the ground, especially in regions with porous rocks such as limestone. The water sinks until it reaches a waterproof layer, then flows sideways until it emerges from the rock as a spring (left).



CUT OFF

Without the water cycle, life on land would be impossible. There would be no plants, and animals cannot survive without plants. There are parts of the world that are cut off from the water cycle, with no clouds or rain. These places are almost as barren as the surface of the Moon.



▲ ATACAMA

The Atacama Desert in Chile is one of the driest places on the planet. Few plants survive here.